line (in front of Bristol Hotel). This is now the effective city-centre but the milestone confidently proclaims that Gurgaon is 6 km away!

The construction of Gurgaon was not planned, although a ‘plan’ did exist in theory. It was made possible by a combination of a lack of rules and the blatant disregard of rules. There was always a whiff of the robber baron. Yet, what was a sleepy small town till the mid-1990s has become a throbbing city of gleaming office towers, metro-stations, malls, luxury hotels and millions of jobs. I am not suggesting that Gurgaon does not have serious civic problems ranging from clogged roads and erratic power supply to the doings of unscrupulous property developers. I have more than enough personal experience of all these issues. It is also true that, with a little imagination, Gurgaon could have been done a lot better. Nonetheless, it is hard to deny the bursting energy of the city. It is a good metaphor for modern India with its private-sector dynamism, the robber-baron element and a government that is struggling to keep up.

THE URBAN FRONTIER [21]

One of the important things that I learnt over years of travelling through the interiors of India is that the children of farmers no longer want to farm. This is true across the country. Well-known sociologist Dipankar Gupta has also documented this phenomenon[22]. There are many reasons for this change. For one, literacy and television are changing attitudes and aspirations. Nevertheless, in my view the biggest reason is economic. The farm economy now generates a shrinking 13 per cent of GDP and the rural population can see where the money is.

City folk tend to have a view that rural migrants get squeezed out of rural areas by the atrocities of feudal landlords who pitilessly exploit the poor villagers. This is an image that derives from old Hindi films and is completely inaccurate on the ground. In fact, there are few large landholdings left in rural India. The real issue is that property rights are unclear because of a shoddy legal system, incomplete records, disregard for common rights and arbitrary land acquisition (often by the State using